

To Bridge The **SKILLS GAP** In The Industry, We Are **COLLABORATING** With **ACADEMIA** To Build On Their Skills And Also Make Them Job Ready

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Why is a tech giant like Unisys investing in a college-level competition for the last twelve years? What's in it for them? And, how did they manage to continue to hire despite the pandemic? Electronics For You spoke to Ravi Shankar Ivaturi, senior director, business operations, Unisys, to find answers to these questions, and here are the excerpts

Q. Why is Unisys investing in such a competition?

A. Cloud 20/20 is celebrating its 12th year now, and Unisys has been known for innovation for over 140 years for building high-performance and security-centric solutions for large enterprises and governments. Unisys is a core technology company. When we started in India, at that time there were only a few such companies in the market. So, we believe that as we are a part of the ecosystem, it is our duty to take leadership and bring the ecosystem together to deal with problems and challenges such as business models, changing trends, etc, through innovation.

For starters, we know that in India, we have some brilliant students with brilliant minds. But when it comes to being in a job, we found out that the students these days are not job ready. To bridge this gap, we thought of coming up with this contest that would serve as a stepping stone for the students into the professional world.

Q. How is the ecosystem contributing to it? In what aspect are they contributing?

A. Talking about academia, we invite students from engineering colleges to submit project ideas. These teams include professors and students. Shortlisted project ideas are further developed into demonstrable POCs (proof of concept) with the help of Unisys mentors. Within Cloud 20/20, we have two different programmes for students:

SIP (Student Innovation Programme): Here, we allow the students to define their own problem statements

in various fields such as government, taxation, securing the Internet, securing railways, etc.

TIP (Targeted Innovation Programme): Here, we along with our clients and partners work on a single (or multiple in some cases) business-specific problem statements. Then it is released in public, and students who want to work on these problem statements can apply.

We get entries from across the country, and the best teams are selected to present their projects in an event held in Bengaluru. The panel that selects these teams comprises our trade bodies, someone from academia, and some of our clients to look at the idea from all the possible angles. This is how all the members in our ecosystem work on different/multiple levels to contribute towards the common goal.

Q. Involving clients into this process increases the chances of them adopting the idea of conducting a similar contest. How does this work? Do you have the confidence or a strong relationship to prevent this from happening?

A. First, let me share our definition of trust, which is competence and character. We approach our clients and partners for participation in the contest with clear guidelines laid out in terms of their roles, responsibilities, and takeaways. We are transparent and collaborative in our approach. Also, Cloud 20/20 is an 11-year-old platform with deep connects in academia. Our relationship with many of the participating institutes goes beyond this contest. We have full faith in the quality of the contest and the bond we have established

with academia over the years.

Q. What happens to IP, especially in TIP? Is there an exchange of IP in such cases?

A. At the start of the relationship, when the students are registered, it is declared that the IP belongs to Unisys, as we are taking the lead in the ecosystem. Also, at the stage of funnelling down the teams, we make an explicit declaration that the IP belongs to Unisys. This helps in ensuring transparency. Talking about innovative ideas and their deployment, we talk to our clients and come up with a suitable decision as to where the IP belongs.

Q. Can you share any success stories where the solution has been given and implemented for a problem statement?

A. This is a new initiative, and we started functioning about two years ago. Though we have great partners and we had good problem statements as well. However, the solutions could not be implemented due to Covid-19. We are hopeful that in the years to come, a few of these solutions will be implemented.

Q. The name Cloud 20/20 was decided twelve years back. However, the programme was implemented two years ago. What was the thought behind the name? Was it because of the year or the IPL?

A. Almost everything that we do nowadays is based on cloud technology. Twelve years ago, we knew that this cloud system is going to be the future of technological developments. However, the 20 by 20 has nothing to do with the year or the IPL. In the western context,